

think the Indian market is a perfect place to have cloud computing in place. From the business owner's point of view, the adoption of cloud computing may not be an easy and quick decision to make as one would have to totally rely on some third party and its IT infrastructure, but once the entire picture is made clear, the industry would soon start adopting cloud computing."

It is not about just the cost of the equipment, at the end of the day. It is about the total infrastructure costs. Shetty adds, "If you want to set up a data centre, the equipment would take about 20 to 25 per cent of the overall cost of the data centre, but the other associated IT resources like power, back-up and cooling require more investments. One would need trained manpower to manage the entire set up as well. So, the story doesn't end with the initial investment of the equipment cost. It's the life cycle cost that matters."

Some of the advantages that cloud solutions offer a start-up are listed below.

Low cost: The cloud will always win over physical storage drives when it comes to money. For a start-up, the cloud can help reduce the IT budget significantly. Owning and maintaining physical storage requires more IT spending, and creating data backups can also make a huge dent in IT budgets.

Easy access: The cloud ensures hassle-free access to stored data. From a start-up or SMB's point of view, maintaining a separate IT team to maintain data will be unaffordable. Also, for non-technical small business owners, the cloud can ensure reliable access to data.

Scalability: The cloud provides the advantage of scalability. A business can scale up or down on the cloud infrastructure, as per its requirement. The scalability can happen within no time and without much investment.

Automation: With cloud computing, IT admins of start-ups need not worry about maintaining applications. One doesn't need to invest in a team to keep the file storage system updated, as most of the applications that run on the cloud are capable of getting updated automatically.

The cloud bridges the gap between start-ups and enterprises

V Ramachandran, country manager, Converged Infrastructure & Cloud Solutions, Cloud Systems, HP India, says, "Cloud technology has the potential to bridge the gap between a small and a large enterprise. With the cloud, small organisations can benefit from the services of world class IT infrastructure. The cloud is slowly spreading its wings across the horizon, as it offers a tremendous amount of reach. Even government departments are now exploring the possibilities of empowering themselves with the cloud as it gives a big boost in providing services to the citizens. Apart from being a cost-effective solution, the cloud can help in managing both resources as well as data effectively. Given the growing number of small businesses in India, the day is not far when

How a start-up benefited from the cloud

Vserv.mobi, a mobile ad network company, is a start-up that leverages cloud technology in a big way. Ashay Padwal, co-founder and chief technology officer, Vserv.mobi, explains the business model, "We host mobile advertisements for our clients. We need to be totally flexible and scalable in order to offer our services perfectly. On a given day we may have only 20,000 ads to host, but the next day our clients may demand hosting of 100,000 advertisements. This kind of scalability is possible only with the cloud. The need for elasticity, when we are unable to estimate the changing hardware requirements from day to day, is one of the crucial reasons that propelled us to deploy a cloud solution in our organisation."

companies from all spheres would look at using cloud computing in a big way."

Cloud telephony: An emerging solution for start-ups

One emerging trend amongst start-ups and SMBs is the adoption of cloud telephony. This can be simply defined as configuring a telephone in a browser. Through cloud telephony, one can virtually carry the desk phones on the browser, and make and receive calls through the computer itself. Cloud telephony is a solution that cuts costs by about five to six times compared to setting up the traditional infrastructure for an ePBX system, with telephone lines and handsets. Ambarish Gupta, chief executive officer, Knowlarity (a cloud telephony company) explains, "A start-up doesn't need to invest in the hardware required for fixed landlines, when it goes for cloud telephony. The traditional telephony set-ups work best when one sets up a proper office. For start-ups, there are hardly any offices in the beginning. So cloud telephony works best for their connectivity from which ever location they are." Cloud telephony can help in better management of time along with the provision for remote working, and increase overall efficiency.

Worries about data security

Cloud computing does provide multiple benefits, but start-ups are still sceptical about data security. Experts opine that small organisations can opt for the cloud any time, but larger organisations are a bit hesitant to give direct control of their IT infrastructure to some third-party vendor. Gadge opines, "Before opting for a cloud solution, customers should evaluate the contract with the service provider. They should be aware enough to understand the security checks in the cloud solution." 

By OSFY Bureau